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Nyoro kinship

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Banyina, then, either *bayineto* or *banyinarumi*, comprise all men and women of the mother's clan of and below the parental generation. From these relatives Banyoro generally look for love and indulgence. With them there is a relationship of familiarity and affection, though this is significantly qualified in the case of *banyinarumi* and their 'sisters' children, *baihwa*. This easy relationship is contrasted by Banyoro with the more formal and authoritarian relationship which obtains between children and their 'fathers'. A mother feeds her child without delay or ceremony when he is hungry. Many Nyoro sayings stress the special consideration to be looked for from one's mother, and she is often contrasted in this respect with the father's other wives. 'You get coarsely ground flour at your mother's house, finely ground flour at your father's other wife's house', a proverb says; the meaning is not that your mother's co-wife feeds you better, but that your mother feeds you quickly and informally without making you wait while an elaborate meal is prepared. A man's duty of affection and consideration for his mother is stressed in the saying: 'On the path where your mother will tread you spread soft leaves, not thorns.'¹ Aged mothers often live with their adult sons; eight out of forty-one household heads in the village of Kihoko had their mothers living with them. This affectionate intimacy also extends to the mother's brothers, *banyinarumi*. The familiar pattern described for many patrilineal African and other peoples² is also found in Bunyoro. A sister's son may take certain liberties in his *nyinarumi*'s house; he may help himself uninvited to food, and may take or borrow almost everything he wants. He may joke familiarly with his mother's brother's wives, though he may not sleep with them. He enjoys these and other privileges in his *nyinarumi*'s home because he is his *nyinarumi*'s 'child' (he is *mwana* as well as *mwihwa*) and *nyinarumi* is his mother. There is a Nyoro proverb which says: 'As long as a brother of my mother remains alive I can count on my *banyinarumi*'s love', and Banyoro often say how happy they were when they visited their mothers' people as children.

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But the relationship between a 'man mother' and his 'child' is significantly different from the relationship between a female mother and her child. Despite the familiarity and affection I have mentioned, there is in the former relationship a latent hostility which finds expression in a wide range of usages. The reasons for this, and the ways in which it is expressed, will be more appropriately considered, for reasons which will be there made plain, in an affinal context in a subsequent article. Here my concern is only with the 'maternal' aspect of the relationship.

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¹ This proverb and the preceding one are quoted in an article by M. B. Davis, 'Lunyoro Proverbs' *Uganda Journal*, vol. viii, No. 3.

² Classically expounded by A. R. Radcliffe-Brown in 'The Mother's Brother in South Africa' in *Structure and Function in Primitive Society* London, 1925, chap. 1.

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